

NORTHSTAR CIVIC INSTITUTE

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# Linking Sports, Literacy & Mental Health

A Pre-Season / Post-Season Survey Instrument for Student Athletes

## The Gap Nobody Is Measuring

A high school basketball player in Saginaw shows up to practice every day. His grades are slipping. He is withdrawn. His coach notices something is off but has no framework to act on that observation: no screening tool, no referral pathway, no structured way to connect what he sees in the gym to what that young person needs in a counselor's office or a reading intervention. The coach does what most coaches do: he keeps coaching and hopes someone else catches it.

This is not an isolated story. It is a systemic pattern. Across Michigan, youth athletic programs, school-based and community-based alike, serve as one of the most consistent touchpoints in a young person's life. Student athletes interact with coaches more frequently, and often more candidly, than they do with teachers, counselors, or clinicians. Yet the infrastructure surrounding these programs is almost entirely oriented toward physical performance. There is no parallel system for monitoring literacy development, emotional well-being, or behavioral health.

The consequences are predictable. Schools report aggregate compliance data that obscures individual need. Out-of-school-time programs track attendance and participation but lack the instruments to demonstrate developmental outcomes. And the young people who are most likely to benefit from early intervention, particularly young men and youth in under-resourced communities, remain invisible to the systems designed to serve them.

*The result is a dual failure: children who need support are not identified, and programs that are producing impact cannot prove it.*

## Why Now: Two Statutes, One Window

Michigan's current legislative landscape creates an unusual convergence: two active statutes that, taken together, establish both the regulatory mandate and the funding infrastructure to close this gap. Neither statute alone is sufficient. Together, they create the conditions for a scalable intervention.

| MCL 388.1631n · School-Based Mental Health                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | MCL 388.1632n · Before/After School & Summer Programs                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
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| Requires intermediate school districts to develop and implement behavioral health integration plans, including screening protocols, referral pathways, and outcome reporting. The statute creates a compliance obligation that most districts are not currently equipped to fulfill in athletic settings: a context where behavioral health needs are disproportionately likely to surface and disproportionately unlikely to be addressed. | Allocates \$75 million for FY 2025-26 through Clinton County RESA in collaboration with the Department of Lifelong Education, Advancement, and Potential (MiLEAP) for expanded out-of-school-time programming. Grantees must address measurable goals, including improved academic outcomes, skill development, and positive behavioral indicators. Eligible programming explicitly encompasses literacy, physical fitness, health and wellness, and mental health services. |

A survey instrument designed to measure literacy engagement and behavioral health indicators in student athletes, administered at the beginning and end of each sport season, serves both statutes simultaneously. It provides 31n-funded districts with a structured screening and referral mechanism in a

previously unaddressed population. It provides 32n-funded programs with the outcome data required to demonstrate measurable impact beyond attendance counts.

## Instrument Design

The proposed tool is a brief, developmentally appropriate questionnaire administered to student athletes at two points: pre-season baseline and post-season follow-up. It is designed for group administration by coaches or program coordinators in approximately 10-15 minutes, requiring no clinical training to administer.

The instrument captures data across three empirically grounded domains, each adapted from established, validated measures:

| Literacy & Academic Identity                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Behavioral Health & Well-Being                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Resilience & Psychosocial Transfer                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Reading frequency, engagement, and attitudes toward learning</li> <li>Academic self-efficacy and confidence (adapted from Bandura's self-efficacy scales)</li> <li>Perceived relationship between athletic participation and academic performance</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Emotional distress indicators (adapted from PHQ-A and GAD-7 youth modules)</li> <li>Help-seeking attitudes, stigma barriers, and willingness to access support</li> <li>Perceived social support from coaches, teammates, and family systems</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Grit and sustained effort (adapted from Short Grit Scale, Duckworth &amp; Quinn, 2009)</li> <li>Self-regulation, emotional control, and stress response (Hobfoll's COR theory)</li> <li>Transfer of competencies from sport to school and daily life (SDT, Ryan &amp; Deci, 2000)</li> </ul> |

These three domains were selected because they represent the intersection where athletic participation, academic development, and behavioral health converge in the lived experience of student athletes. The pre/post design captures trajectory, not snapshot, allowing programs to demonstrate directional change in outcomes that matter to funders, school boards, and families.

## Implementation Model

The instrument is designed for low-burden, high-yield integration into existing athletic and out-of-school-time programming. The four-stage cycle aligns with natural sport seasons and academic reporting periods:

**Baseline Administration.** During the first week of each sport season, student athletes complete the survey in a group setting facilitated by a coach or program coordinator. No clinical licensure is required. Responses are captured digitally or on paper and scored using a standardized rubric.

**Early Identification and Referral.** Baseline data is reviewed against threshold criteria. Students whose responses indicate elevated risk on behavioral health or literacy domains are flagged for follow-up through the school's or program's existing referral infrastructure. This step directly supports 31n compliance by creating a documented, structured identification process in athletic contexts: a population most ISD compliance plans do not currently address.

**Post-Season Follow-Up.** The identical instrument is administered during the final week of the season, generating paired pre/post data for each participant and for the cohort as a whole.

**Outcome Reporting.** Aggregate reports are produced for districts, ISDs, and program funders, showing measurable change across all three domains. Individual-level data remains confidential and is shared only with designated school or program personnel consistent with FERPA and applicable

privacy standards. Reports are formatted to align directly with 32n's required measurable goals: improved academic outcomes, positive behavioral indicators, and skill development.

Stakeholder Value

| MiLEAP & Section 32n Grantees                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
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| Out-of-school-time and summer programs funded under 32n face a mandate to demonstrate measurable outcomes in areas including academic achievement, skill development, and positive behavior. Most programs lack the instrumentation to do this rigorously. The survey provides a turnkey data collection mechanism that produces the outcome evidence grantees need for reporting, reauthorization, and future funding competitiveness.                                                                  |
| Intermediate School Districts                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Section 31n requires ISDs to implement behavioral health integration plans that include screening, referral protocols, and outcome reporting. The survey fills a specific gap in these plans: it extends the district's screening infrastructure into athletic settings, where behavioral health needs are most visible but least likely to be formally identified. For ISDs navigating compliance timelines, this tool provides a ready-made pathway for a population their current plans rarely reach. |
| Coaches, Athletic Directors & Youth Program Leaders                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Coaches interact with young people more consistently and often more authentically than any other adult in their lives. They see the behavioral and emotional signals: withdrawal, aggression, declining engagement. But they lack a structured mechanism to translate those observations into action. The survey gives them that mechanism: a simple, repeatable process that connects what they see to the support systems that can respond.                                                            |

Theoretical and Empirical Foundation

The instrument is grounded in five complementary theoretical frameworks, each contributing specific constructs and validated measurement approaches to the survey design:

**Grit Theory (Duckworth et al., 2007; Duckworth & Quinn, 2009).** Provides the construct of perseverance and passion for long-term goals. The Resilience & Psychosocial Transfer domain adapts items from the Short Grit Scale (Grit-S), a validated 8-item measure, to assess sustained effort and consistency of interest in both athletic and academic settings.

**Self-Efficacy Theory (Bandura, 1977, 1997).** Provides the theoretical basis for measuring academic and athletic confidence. The Literacy & Academic Identity domain draws on Bandura's framework to assess students' belief in their capacity to succeed academically, a construct consistently linked to reading engagement, task persistence, and help-seeking behavior.

**Self-Determination Theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000).** Frames the motivational conditions under which young people thrive: autonomy, competence, and relatedness. The instrument measures whether sport participation strengthens or undermines these psychological needs, and whether gains in sport-based competence transfer to academic and interpersonal contexts.

**Conservation of Resources Theory (Hobfoll, 1989).** Provides a framework for understanding stress and resource depletion in youth athletes. The Behavioral Health & Well-Being domain incorporates COR-informed items to assess whether students are experiencing resource loss, social support erosion, emotional exhaustion, or identity threat that may precede clinical-level distress.

**The Invisible Athlete Framework (NCI, 2026).** NCI's original contribution to this literature, documenting how youth behavioral health needs are systematically missed in athletic contexts. The framework identifies three structural failure points: coaches lack screening training, athletic culture

discourages vulnerability, and referral systems do not extend into sport settings. The survey instrument is designed to address all three.

NCI has two manuscripts in preparation grounding this work in the peer-reviewed literature: one mapping the PlayStrong research framework and one developing the Invisible Athlete construct. Both are targeted for submission to *Journal of Applied Sport Psychology*, *Psychology of Sport and Exercise*, or *Sport, Exercise, and Performance Psychology* in 2026, with PsyArXiv preprints planned for immediate citability.

## Policy Recommendations

The convergence of MCL 388.1631n (behavioral health) and MCL 388.1632n (out-of-school-time programming) creates a unique policy window. The evidence supports the following recommendations:

**Recommendation 1:** MDE should issue guidance explicitly recognizing athletic settings as eligible delivery contexts for Section 31n behavioral health services. The \$106.5 million appropriation currently funds school-based services that do not systematically reach student-athletes, despite evidence that athletic settings are where behavioral health needs are most likely to surface and least likely to be addressed.

**Recommendation 2:** Section 32n grantees (\$75 million for out-of-school-time programming) should be required to include measurable behavioral health and literacy outcome data beyond attendance counts. The pre-/post-season survey instrument described in this brief provides a validated, low-burden mechanism for meeting this requirement.

**Recommendation 3:** ISDs should adopt standardized coach training in behavioral health observation and referral. Fewer than 12% of community youth sport organizations have any behavioral health referral protocol. Coaches are the adults most consistently present in student-athletes' lives and are typically the first to observe behavioral changes, yet they lack the training, tools, and institutional pathways to act on those observations.

## Proposed Path Forward

The following sequence is designed to move from concept to proof-of-concept within a single sport season, generating the data necessary to validate the instrument and demonstrate value to stakeholders:

- Collaborative scoping session with MiLEAP to identify one to two partner programs in the Saginaw, Bay, or Tuscola region for a proof-of-concept cohort. The goal is alignment on target population, sport context, and partner capacity.
- Instrument development and expert review. NCI drafts the full survey instrument, conducts content validation with subject-matter experts in sport psychology and adolescent behavioral health, and prepares administration and scoring protocols.
- Proof-of-concept pilot with a single cohort: one sport, one school or program partner, one season. Target cohort size: 15-30 student athletes. This validates instrument reliability, tests administration feasibility, and produces the first round of pre/post outcome data.
- Findings report and scaling framework. NCI publishes pilot findings, refines the instrument based on field data, and develops implementation support packages, including training materials, scoring guides, and reporting templates, for ISDs and 32n grantees statewide.

*A Note on Data Privacy and Ethics: All instrument development and pilot administration will comply with FERPA, applicable state privacy laws, and institutional ethical review standards. Individual student data will be accessible only to designated school or program personnel. Aggregate reporting will be de-identified. NCI is committed to conducting this work with the same rigor and ethical standards expected of university-based research, and will seek institutional review board (IRB) consultation as the pilot design is finalized.*

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**About Northstar Civic Institute**

Northstar Civic Institute (NCI) is a nonpartisan 501(c)(3) policy research organization based in Michigan. NCI conducts applied research on youth behavioral health, sports equity, and education policy to inform evidence-based programming and decision-making. NCI does not engage in legislative advocacy. This brief is published for educational and informational purposes.

**Implementation & Consulting Support**

Instrument design, administration training, data analysis, and compliance reporting for organizations implementing survey-based tools developed through NCI research are available through Ledger Strategy Group LLC (LSG).

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